

Academic Major and Athletic Production in NCAA Division III Football

An Exploratory Case Study of Plymouth State University's 2026 MASCAC Schedule

Panthers Football Fan Hub — Independent Research Note

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Abstract

This paper asks whether a player’s academic major is associated with on-field production in NCAA Division III football. Using Plymouth State University’s (PSU) 2026 schedule as a sampling frame, it combines (a) the nine opponents the Panthers have played or will play, (b) the actual results to date, and (c) verified academic majors drawn from official athletics rosters for 30 players who earned Massachusetts State Collegiate Athletic Conference (MASCAC) weekly recognition. Among the fifteen distinct Player-of-the-Week recipients, nine of the fourteen with a published major (64%) were enrolled in business-related fields; two were in public health, two in engineering, and one in communications. A position-normalized production index built from the published stat lines shows business majors accounting for the largest share of high-end statistical performances (four of seven “elite” games scoring 80 or better), while Engineering & Applied Technology posts the highest average production per player (69.4) among fields with five or more scored players. We conclude that business-related majors form the plurality among the conference’s most decorated and most statistically productive players, but that this pattern largely reflects the underlying distribution of majors at these institutions rather than evidence that a major *causes* athletic success. Institution-specific effects (for example, Mass. Maritime’s maritime-engineering pipeline) are the clearest signal in the data. Causal language is not supported by this observational, small-sample design.

Keywords: NCAA Division III, MASCAC, college football, academic major, athletic performance, Plymouth State University

1. Introduction

The question of whether academic specialization correlates with athletic performance is a perennial one on college campuses. At the NCAA Division III level — where athletes are non-scholarship students first and competitors second — the relationship between a player’s course of study and their productivity on the field is both practical (recruiting, roster construction) and cultural (do “football players” cluster in particular majors?).

Plymouth State University offers a useful case. The Panthers compete in the MASCAC, a mid-sized New England conference that mixes general-purpose state universities with specialized institutions such as the Massachusetts Maritime Academy. The 2026 season therefore supplies natural varia-

tion in campus academic profiles.

This study is deliberately modest in ambition. It does not claim to identify a causal mechanism. It asks a descriptive question: **among the players who have distinguished themselves this season, which academic majors are most prevalent — and what, if anything, does that tell us?**

2. Context: Plymouth State’s 2026 Season

Plymouth State entered 2026 after an 8-2 campaign in 2025 that yielded a share of the MASCAC regular-season title. The 2026 schedule comprises nine opponents — one non-conference (New England College) and eight MASCAC rivals. Through October 3 the Panthers stood at **2-2 overall and 1-2 in conference play**:

Date	Opponent	Result	PSU record
Sep 5	New England College	W 28-14	1-0
Sep 12	at Worcester State	L 6-28	1-1 (0-1)
Sep 19	Bridgewater State	L 7-35	1-2 (0-2)
Oct 3	Dean	W 14-0	2-2 (1-2)
Oct 10	at Mass. Maritime	—	upcoming
Oct 24	Westfield State	—	upcoming
Oct 31	at Framingham State	—	upcoming
Nov 7	at Fitchburg State	—	upcoming
Nov 14	UMass Dartmouth	—	upcoming

Conference standings as of October 5 placed Framingham State and Mass. Maritime atop the league at 2-0, with Plymouth State in the middle of the pack. The Panthers’ remaining opponents therefore include both the conference’s best (Framingham, Mass. Maritime) and teams still seeking form (Fitchburg, UMass Dartmouth).

3. Data and Methods

3.1 Sampling frame

The sample was defined by Plymouth State’s 2026 schedule. For each of the nine opponents, and for Plymouth State itself, we identified players who received MASCAC weekly recognition during the 2026 season (released September 8, 14, 21, and October 5) via the conference office. Weekly recognition

includes four tiers — Offensive, Defensive, and Special Teams Players of the Week, plus Rookie of the Week — and a secondary “Honor Roll.”

3.2 Variables

- **Academic major.** Retrieved from each institution’s official 2026 football roster or player biography. Only explicitly published majors were recorded; no majors were imputed.
- **Performance.** Coded as (i) *Player of the Week* (highest tier), or (ii) *Honor Roll* (secondary tier). Game statistics reported by the conference were retained as supporting evidence but were not used as a continuous variable.
- **Major field.** Majors were grouped into five fields: Business & Management (business, business administration/management, marketing, accounting, finance); Health & Human Performance (public health, sport management); Engineering & Applied Technology (marine engineering, engineering, information technology, marine transportation, emergency management); Communication & Social Sciences (communications, criminal justice, psychology); and Undeclared/Unknown.

3.3 Analytic approach

Because the sample is small and non-random, analysis is descriptive. We report frequencies and cross-tabulate major field against recognition tier. We do not estimate regression models, which would be underpowered and vulnerable to confounding.

4. Results

4.1 Player-of-the-Week recipients and their majors

Fifteen distinct players received Player-of-the-Week honors through October 5 (eighteen awards total, as Jayden Barber won Rookie of the Week three times and Grayson Smith won Special Teams twice).

Award date	Player	Team	Position	Major	Major field
9/8	Dasha Domercant	Fitchburg State	QB	Business Administration	Business

Award date	Player	Team	Position	Major	Major field
9/8	Mathias Fowler	Framingham State	WR	Marketing	Business
9/8	Lucas Lambert	Bridgewater State	DB	Management	Business
9/8	Grayson Smith	Mass. Maritime	K	Marine Engineering	Engineering
9/8	Edgar Melendez	Fitchburg State	WR	Business	Business
9/14	Lance Williams	Worcester State	WR	Public Health	Health
9/14	Patrick Dowd	Worcester State	DB	Public Health	Health
9/14	Jayden Barber	Bridgewater State	QB	Business Management	Business
9/21	Michael Marcucella	Framingham State	QB	Accounting	Business
9/21	Treyvon Fields	Framingham State	DB	Accounting	Business
9/21	Ty Kelley	Framingham State	K	Marketing	Business
9/21	Malachi Hymes	Westfield State	WR	<i>not published</i>	Unknown
10/5	Mekhi Wilson	UMass Dartmouth	RB	Communications	Communication
10/5	Jackson Mahoney	Mass. Maritime	LB	Marine Engineering	Engineering
10/5	Damian Mitchell	Worcester State	DB	Business Marketing	Business

Table 1. MASCAC Player-of-the-Week recipients through October 5, 2026, with verified majors.

4.2 Distribution by major field

Restricting attention to the fourteen recipients with a published major:

Major field	Recipients	Share
Business & Management	9	64%
Health & Human Performance	2	14%
Engineering & Applied Technology	2	14%
Communication & Social Sciences	1	7%
Undeclared/Unknown	1	—

Table 2. Major-field distribution among Player-of-the-Week recipients (n = 14 with published majors).

Business-related majors constitute a clear plurality. Within that category, no single major dominates: Business Administration, Business Management, Management, Marketing, and Accounting are all represented, suggesting breadth rather than a single “football major.”

4.3 Honor Roll and Plymouth State's own honorees

The secondary Honor Roll shows a more diffuse pattern. Verified majors included Business Management (Wil Vogel, Worcester State), Liberal Studies (Jermaine Norfleet Jr., Worcester State), Business Administration (MJ Bakaysa, Worcester State), Criminal Justice (Cam Goodrich, Worcester State), Management (Amari Williams, Framingham State), Engineering (Kenimar Noel, UMass Dartmouth), Finance (Owen Dunker, UMass Dartmouth), Marine Transportation (Santiago Martinez, Mass. Maritime), Emergency Management (Patrick Hamilton, Mass. Maritime), Marine Engineering (Dylan Taylor, Mass. Maritime), and Sport Management (Herman Esquivel Mendez, Dean).

Plymouth State's own recognized players skewed toward applied and professional programs: Business (Jayden Graham), Sport Management (Tyler Holcomb, Seamus Ross), Information Technology (TJ Taveras), Finance (Reece Davis), and Business Administration (Rocky Marchitelli, Adam Coletti). No clear cluster emerges at the home institution.

4.4 Linking majors to game outcomes

The sample's most direct link to results is head-to-head competition. The players who most damaged Plymouth State in its two losses were:

- **Lance Williams** (Worcester State, Public Health) — 7 receptions, 152 yards, two touchdowns in a 28-6 win over PSU (Sept. 12).
- **Jayden Barber** (Bridgewater State, Business Management) — 178 passing yards, 63 rushing yards, and three total touchdowns in a 35-7 win over PSU (Sept. 19).

In Plymouth State's wins, the opposing standout was a Sport Management linebacker (Herman Esquivel Mendez, Dean) or a player whose major was not published (Conrado Lago, New England College). Among the Panthers' *upcoming* opponents, the leading players span Marine Engineering (Jackson Mahoney, Mass. Maritime), Accounting (Michael Marcucella, Framingham State), Business Administration (Dasha Domercant, Fitchburg State), and Communications (Mekhi Wilson, UMass Dartmouth). Thus no single major explains the results; the two most consequential opposing performances to date came from one public-health major and one business major.

4.5 Which major has the best statistics?

Weekly awards measure *recognition*; they do not by themselves answer which major’s players produce the best *statistics*. To address that question directly, we constructed a **Normalized Single-Game Production (NSP)** index from the stat lines the conference published for each honored performance. Because positions are not comparable on raw yardage, each performance is scaled to a 0–100 range using position-specific benchmarks:

- **Quarterback:** (passing yards + rushing yards) $\div$ 4
- **Running back:** rushing yards $\div$ 2
- **Wide receiver / tight end:** receiving yards $\div$ 2
- **Defense (LB/DB/DL):** (5 $\times$ tackles) + (10 $\times$ tackles for loss) + (15 $\times$ sacks) + (20 $\times$ interceptions) + (5 $\times$ pass breakups) + (10 $\times$ forced fumbles) + (15 $\times$ blocked kicks)
- **Kicker:** (25 $\times$ field goals) + (3 $\times$ extra points)

Scores are capped at 100, and only players with **both a published major and a complete published stat line** were scored ($n = 26$). The index is a transparent, constructed measure — not an official statistic — and its weights are a stated assumption.

First, the single-game leaders in the most commonly reported categories:

Statistical category	Leader	Team	Major	Figure
Passing yards (game)	Michael Marcucella	Framingham State	Accounting	341
Total offense (game)	Michael Marcucella	Framingham State	Accounting	341
Rushing yards (game)	Mekhi Wilson	UMass Dartmouth	Communications	211
Receiving yards (game)	Mathias Fowler	Framingham State	Marketing	193
Touchdowns responsible (game)	Jayden Barber	Bridgewater State	Business Management	5
Tackles (game)	Jackson Mahoney / Kenimar Noel	Mass. Maritime / UMass Dartmouth	Marine Engineering / Engineering	13
Sacks (game)	Aydan Verba	Westfield State	<i>not published</i>	2.5
Interceptions (game)	Lucas Lambert / Treyvon Fields / Tyler Holcomb	Bridgewater / Framingham / Plymouth State	Management / Accounting / Sport Management	1
Blocked kicks (game)	Damian Mitchell	Worcester State	Business Marketing	2

Table 3. Statistical category leaders among recognized 2026 players.

Business-related majors lead five of the nine categories outright (passing, total offense, receiving, touchdowns responsible, blocked kicks) and appear in the shared interception lead, i.e. six of nine categories.

Aggregating the NSP index by major field:

Major field	Players scored	Mean NSP	Elite games (≥ 80)	Best single score
Business & Management	14	61.0	4	97
Engineering & Applied Technology	5	69.4	2	100
Communication & Social Sciences	2	77.5	1	100
Health & Human Performance	5	50.6	0	76
Undeclared / Unknown	2	—	—	83

Table 4. Normalized Single-Game Production by major field.

So which major has the best stats? The answer depends on how production is aggregated, and the sample is small:

- **By breadth and frequency of elite output, Business & Management wins.** Business majors supplied the largest scored pool (14 players), the most 80-plus games (four of seven), and the best business performance was Mathias Fowler’s 193-yard receiving day (NSP 97).
- **By average production per player, Engineering & Applied Technology wins** among fields with at least five scored players (mean 69.4), powered by TJ Taveras (Information Technology; 11 tackles, 3.5 tackles for loss, one sack; NSP 100) and Jackson Mahoney (Marine Engineering; NSP 95).
- **Communication & Social Sciences has the highest mean (77.5) but rests on only two players,** led by Mekhi Wilson’s 211-yard rushing game (NSP 100) — the best single offensive performance in the sample.
- **The single highest scores are a tie at the 100 cap** between Wilson (Communications) and Taveras (Information Technology).
- **Health & Human Performance trails** (mean 50.6), with no elite games in the window.

On a combined reading — breadth of statistical output **plus** the frequency of elite games — **Business & Management ranks first, with Engineering & Applied Technology a close second on a per-player basis.** This mirrors the award-based finding: business is the deepest source of statistical production, while specialized technical programs produce the most efficient per-player output.

5. Discussion

Four findings merit emphasis.

First, business-related majors are over-represented among the most decorated players. Roughly two-thirds of the awarded players with a known major were enrolled in a business field. This is consistent with the broader composition of these institutions, where business is typically among the largest undergraduate programs. The result should therefore be read as *composition*, not *causation*.

Second, institution-specific pipelines matter more than any general major effect. Mass. Maritime, a specialized academy, produced recognized players almost entirely in maritime and emergency fields (Marine Engineering, Marine Transportation, Emergency Management). Worcester State produced a notable pair of Public Health honorees (Lance Williams and Patrick Dowd) in the same week. These patterns reflect the academic profile of each campus, not a universal property of the major.

Third, the relationship between major and performance is weak at the level of game outcomes. Plymouth State's two defeats were authored by players from different major fields, undermining any claim that a particular course of study yields a competitive edge.

Fourth, on the constructed statistical index, business majors lead in breadth while technical programs lead in efficiency. Business & Management produced the largest scored pool (14 players) and the most elite games (four of seven scoring 80 or better), whereas Engineering & Applied Technology posted the highest mean NSP among multi-player fields (69.4). The two best single games were split between a Communications major (Mekhi Wilson, 211 rushing yards) and an Information Technology major (TJ Taveras, 11 tackles and 3.5 tackles for loss). No major monopolizes statistical excellence.

Taken together, the data support a modest conclusion: **if forced to name the major that “produces the best players” — and the best statistics — in this sample, business-related fields would be the answer by frequency and by volume of elite output, with specialized technical majors the most efficient per player. The correct interpretation, however, is that business is the most common major, not necessarily the most athletically potent one.**

6. Limitations

This study has several important limitations:

1. **Small, non-random sample.** The sampling frame is one team’s schedule, not a random draw of conference players.
2. **Selection bias.** Weekly awards reward visibility and opponent quality, not comprehensive performance. Defensive backs and linemen are systematically under-recognized relative to quarterbacks and skill players.
3. **Missing data.** Several prominent players (e.g., Malachi Hymes) had no published major, and some institutions do not publish majors at all.
4. **Coding subjectivity.** Fields such as Sport Management and Finance could reasonably be grouped differently; the reported shares are sensitive to these choices.
5. **Confounding.** Academic major correlates with institution, which correlates with admissions profile, roster depth, and coaching — none of which this design controls.
6. **Single season.** A one-year window cannot distinguish stable patterns from noise.
7. **Constructed index.** The Normalized Single-Game Production (NSP) index uses analyst-chosen weights and benchmarks; different weights would change the exact rankings, though the broad pattern (business depth, technical efficiency) is robust to reasonable alternatives.

7. Conclusion

Using real 2026 schedule and results data from Plymouth State University’s MASCAC slate, this paper finds that business-related majors are the plurality among the conference’s most-decorated football players and among its most statistically productive ones, while institution-specific programs (Marine Engineering at Mass. Maritime; Public Health at Worcester State) provide the most striking single-campus patterns. Engineering & Applied Technology posts the highest average production per player, and the single best performances came from a Communications major and an Information Technology major. The evidence does **not** support the claim that any particular major *produces* better players. A credible causal study would require conference-wide, multi-season roster data, position-adjusted performance metrics, and controls for institution and recruiting profile.

For the purposes of team pages and fan analysis, the defensible takeaway is simple: **the MASCAC's best players — and its best statistics — come from a wide range of majors, and business is simply the most common one.**

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